

2025 Trade War Crash and Aftermath: Timeline and Reactions

April 2025 – “Liberation Day” Tariffs Trigger a Market Meltdown

In early April 2025, President Donald Trump shocked global markets by unveiling the steepest U.S. trade tariffs in over a century[1]. On April 2, he announced “**Liberation Day**” tariffs – a **10% baseline duty on all U.S. imports** starting April 5, with **much higher country-specific rates from April 9**[2]. These included a **34% tariff on Chinese goods, 46% on imports from Vietnam, 24% on Japan, and 20% on the EU**[2]. Tariffs of 25% on foreign auto imports also took effect[2]. This sweeping protectionist move – the largest trade barriers imposed by Washington in over 100 years[1] – blindsided investors and ignited a massive sell-off.

Global Market Collapse: Stocks plunged worldwide as investors braced for recession. The S&P 500 cratered 4.8% on April 3 (its worst day since June 2020), the Nasdaq dived 6% (worst since March 2020), and U.S. equities shed **\$2.4 trillion in value in one day**[3][4]. Volatility spiked – the VIX fear index hit its highest since 2024[5]. Globally, markets fared even worse: **Hong Kong’s Hang Seng plummeted 13.3% on April 7** (the worst one-day drop since 1997)[6][7], **Japan’s Nikkei fell 7.8%**, and trading was halted across Asia as circuit breakers tripped[6][8]. European stocks also slid ~2.5% as the EU warned of “countermeasures” in response[9]. Investors rushed into safe havens – **Treasury yields sank to 4.0%** (signaling a flight to quality)[10], the dollar fell to 6-month lows vs. the yen[11], and gold initially jumped (though it later fell amid volatility)[12].

Political Reactions (U.S., China, EU): Defiant responses poured in. **Trump shrugged off the market carnage**, insisting “I think it’s going very well” and predicting “markets are going to boom” eventually[13]. He showed no sign of reversing course despite the rout. Meanwhile, **Beijing retaliated forcefully**. On April 4, China’s Finance Ministry blasted the U.S. move as “a typical unilateral bullying practice” violating WTO rules[14]. China announced **sweeping countermeasures: effective April 10, 34% extra tariffs on all U.S. goods** (bringing total new Chinese duties to 54% this year)[15][16]. Beijing also **curbed exports of rare earth metals** to the U.S. and added dozens of U.S. companies to an “unreliable entities” blacklist[17][18]. “China played it wrong, they panicked – the one thing they cannot afford to do!” Trump taunted on Truth Social, claiming Beijing was flailing[19]. **Europe’s leaders also bristled:** EU chief Ursula von der Leyen condemned the U.S. tariffs as a “major blow” to the world economy and said Europe was ready with **25% counter-tariffs on U.S. goods like soybeans, nuts and sausages**[20]. European officials vowed not to “surrender” to U.S. pressure. In the words of one Brussels diplomat, “We will not be the ones to blink first.” This set the stage for a global trade war.

Fed and Institutions: Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell struck a cautious tone. In an April 4 speech, Powell noted the tariff shock would “**likely raise inflation**” in coming

quarters while **slowing growth**, creating a vexing dilemma for the Fed[21][22]. He signaled a hold on interest rates “*to wait for greater clarity*” on the tariffs’ impact[23]. Powell pointedly rejected the idea of a Fed “put” to save markets, emphasizing the Fed can’t shield investors from trade policy fallout[24][25]. This hawkish stance – effectively warning that **tariffs could cause** “difficult economic times...both in terms of inflation and growth” **without immediate Fed rescue** – rattled Wall Street further[26][27]. “Powell is confirming what investors feared,” noted CFRA’s Sam Stovall, “more stubborn inflation and slowing growth due to tariffs”[28]. Major banks began slashing forecasts: J.P. Morgan warned the tariff “**waterfall event**” could tip the U.S. into recession, cutting its S&P 500 earnings outlook[29]. Edward Jones strategist Mona Mahajan said the **scope of tariffs “exceeded even the most bearish forecasts”** and markets now grasp their “**meaningful impact on growth and obviously inflation**”[30]. The consensus was that the Fed’s dual mandate was in jeopardy – one analyst quipped that tariffs had “**both sides of the coin going the wrong way for the Fed**” (higher prices and rising unemployment)[22].

Retail Investor Sentiment: Amid the chaos, some bold retail investors saw opportunity. On trading forums, the emerging narrative was “**buy the dip because Trump always backs down.**” Indeed, by mid-April many small investors were bargain-hunting stocks beaten down by tariff fears. This contrarian view – encapsulated by the tongue-in-cheek acronym “**TACO**” (**Trump Always Chickens Out**) – gained traction on Wall Street[31][32]. As one commentator observed, “**whenever Donald Trump faces a market backlash, he will back down**”[31]. Early evidence supported this: after each prior tariff threat in Trump’s tenure, he had eventually softened. Some retail traders wagered that pattern would hold, scooping up shares at “fire sale” prices in hopes of a policy reversal. On social media, a popular meme was “*Trump’s tariffs make stocks go on sale – time to buy!*” However, skepticism remained among more cautious investors. As the **S&P 500 sank over 12% below its February peak** by early April[33], many feared a bear market was unfolding without a clear bottom.

Late April: Market Bottom and the “TACO” Reversal

Through mid-April, markets remained extremely volatile. By April 20, however, equities appeared to find a floor as investors bet that Trump’s hardball tactics would not last. That week, the White House quietly began signaling flexibility: multiple countries entered negotiations seeking exemptions from the tariffs. Indeed, **trading chatter suggested a tariff pause or rollback might be imminent** if the sell-off continued. This speculative optimism, combined with technical “oversold” conditions, helped stocks **grind off their lows after April 20.**

The turning point came when **Trump himself blinked.** Facing mounting political pressure and a furious lobbying campaign by U.S. businesses, Trump decided to partially roll back his tariff offensive. On **April 9**, just as the harshest duties on China were to kick in, **Trump announced a 90-day tariff suspension for most U.S. allies**[34][35]. In effect, **tariff implementation for countries other than China was delayed until July 9**, giving trade partners a window to negotiate deals. This concession – exempting the EU, Canada,

Mexico, and others from immediate hikes – was a bid to calm markets and isolate Beijing. Crucially, it came only hours after an extraordinary public intervention by Trump on social media.

Trump’s “Buy the Dip” Moment: On the morning of April 9, **Trump took to his Truth Social account to jawbone the stock market higher**, in a move that stunned observers. Shortly after the opening bell, as stocks wobbled, he posted upbeat messages: *“BE COOL! Everything is going to work out well. The USA will be bigger and better than ever!”* This was followed by an even more explicit market-timing signal: *“THIS IS A GREAT TIME TO BUY!!!”*^{[36][37]}. The president of the United States was effectively telling investors to buy stocks *minutes* before news broke that he would pause tariffs broadly^[38]. When Trump soon announced the tariff truce (sparing allies and limiting the China duties to 34% rather than a mooted 100+%), **stocks absolutely skyrocketed**. The S&P 500 and Dow each leapt ~5% in a day – one of their biggest one-day gains in decades^{[39][40]}. The Dow surged nearly 1,200 points on April 9-10, and the tech-heavy Nasdaq roared back 4.4%^[39]. “It was like a switch flipped,” marveled one trader – panic selling turned to a buying frenzy within hours.

Trump’s market call immediately raised **eyebrows about potential manipulation**. Critics noted the President’s social media “buy” tip preceded market-moving policy news, sparking calls for an insider trading probe^[38]. **India Today** reported a “firestorm of scrutiny” and questions about whether **Trump or his allies profited from the wild swings**^[38]. On Wall Street, cynical voices suggested this pattern was no coincidence: *“The climbdown happened because he and his friends already profited on the way down, now it’s time to profit on the way up,”* scoffed one market commentator^{[41][42]}. While no evidence of illegal trading emerged, the **optics of Trump’s perfectly-timed bullish tweet and tariff U-turn were unsettling**. Nonetheless, the immediate effect was clear – the **“TACO trade” paid off**. Investors who had bet on Trump to chicken out were vindicated, and a powerful relief rally was underway.

Media and Expert Reactions: The dramatic rebound by late April led to a new narrative. The **Guardian** observed that *“Wall Street is increasingly betting that Trump will blink first”* in any stand-off^{[43][31]}. Financial Times columnist Robert Armstrong formally coined the **“TACO”** acronym on May 2 to summarize this prevailing belief^[44]. Investors essentially assumed **any Trump-induced sell-off would be temporary**, since he would reverse course if markets fell too far^[32]. This dynamic created a resilient (if volatile) trading environment – U.S. indices, after plunging in early April, **actually ended May 2025 up slightly year-to-date**^[32]. The “Trump put” had replaced the Fed put, some joked, with stock speculators front-running Trump’s inevitable retreats.

Not everyone welcomed this state of affairs. Critics argued that **Trump’s erratic policymaking was undermining U.S. credibility** and could backfire if adversaries called his bluff. When a reporter on May 29 asked Trump about the “Trump Always Chickens Out” theory, the President grew visibly angry^{[45][46]}. *“Don’t ever say what you said... That’s a nasty question,”* Trump snapped, denying he was “chicken” while paradoxically boasting

about having imposed high tariffs (and then cutting some)[47]. His thin-skinned response only reinforced the **perception that market narratives were influencing his decisions**. As the Guardian dryly noted, “*the partial climbdowns have often followed close behind slumping bond prices*”, suggesting Trump reacted whenever financial stress mounted[48][49]. In other words, **Trump’s market manipulation (or at least market reactivity) became an open secret by late spring 2025**.

May 2025 – Trade Truce and a “Stock Party” in the Middle East

90-Day Tariff Truce: On May 12, the United States and China formally declared a **90-day tariff truce**, validating hopes that cooler heads would prevail. After talks in Geneva, both sides agreed to **mutually reduce certain tariffs and halt further escalations for 90 days**[50][51]. This deal (effective May 14) **capped U.S. tariffs on Chinese goods at 30% and Chinese tariffs on U.S. goods at 10% during the truce**[52][53], averting a spiral toward triple-digit duties. It meant Trump suspended the threatened 145% tariff doomsday scenario, and Beijing likewise paused its next retaliation[52][54]. The timing was not coincidental – U.S. retailers were heading into the crucial holiday import season, and a tariff reprieve “provided much-needed relief for supply chain planning”[52][55]. Markets responded with euphoria. On May 13, the S&P 500 posted its best day in months, +3.3%, and the Dow jumped another 600+ points[40][39]. “**Indexes soared... on optimism over the temporary trade deal**”, Investopedia noted[40][39]. Tech stocks, in particular, rebounded as China agreed to **lift its ban on Boeing plane deliveries** and other goodwill gestures[56]. The tariff truce removed, for the moment, the “sword of Damocles” hanging over corporate earnings.

Trump’s Middle East Mega-Deals: Fresh off the trade ceasefire, President Trump embarked on a high-profile **Middle East tour from May 13–16**, which became another catalyst for stocks. Before departing, Trump again **teased investors with cryptic bullish hints**. He touted that an upcoming event would be “*the most impactful and important*” for the economy and suggested “**it’s a good time to buy stocks**” – remarks widely interpreted as foreshadowing major deals on his trip. Many believe Trump already had positive feedback from Gulf leaders via phone and was effectively **telegraphing a market boost**. The trip did not disappoint. Over four days in **Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and the UAE**, Trump announced **hundreds of billions – even trillions – of dollars in business agreements**[57][58]. The scope was staggering:

- **Saudi Arabia:** The Saudi government and Aramco signed **34 deals with U.S. companies worth up to \$90 billion**[58]. Saudi’s PIF sovereign fund committed to multi-billion investments with U.S. firms (e.g. \$5 billion with Franklin Templeton)[59][60]. Tech standouts included **Nvidia selling 18,000 of its latest AI chips to a new Saudi AI initiative**[61][62], and **Qualcomm partnering on a chip R&D center in Arabia**[61].
- **United Arab Emirates:** Abu Dhabi’s Etihad Airways agreed to **buy 28 Boeing jetliners (\$14.5 billion) with GE engines**[63]. U.S. energy firms Exxon, Occidental,

and EOG pledged **\$60 billion for UAE oil & gas projects**[64]. A landmark nuclear energy partnership saw Holtec International and an Emirati firm plan to build small modular reactors in the U.S., with **up to \$30 billion funded by UAE investors**[65]. The UAE also would bankroll a new \$4 billion aluminum plant in Oklahoma[66].

- **Qatar:** Qatar Airways inked a deal to **purchase Boeing jets** (further bolstering Boeing's order book)[67]. U.S. engineering firm Parsons secured **\$97 billion worth of projects in Qatar**[68]. Additionally, U.S. asset manager Neuberger Berman and BlackRock arranged **multi-billion investment platforms** with Qatar and Saudi Arabia[69].

In total, the White House touted **over \$600 billion in new investments** during the trip's first days[70], and some analysts estimated the long-term value above \$1–2 **trillion** when including tentative commitments[71][57]. The deals spanned **aviation, energy, infrastructure, finance, and AI – injecting huge potential windfalls for American firms**. Notably, **Boeing, General Electric, Lockheed Martin, ExxonMobil, Nvidia, and other U.S. stocks surged** as details emerged. Forbes observed **major U.S. tech and industrial shares rallied strongly “amid Trump’s four-day Middle East trip”**[72]. The market's verdict: Trump's dealmaking blitz would boost corporate revenues and profits.

“Stock Party” Atmosphere: With trade tensions cooling and fresh overseas deals to celebrate, late May felt like a **“stock market party.”** The S&P 500 and Nasdaq climbed steadily throughout Trump's Gulf tour – the Nasdaq even notched a record high by month's end, fueled by the AI frenzy and confidence that Trump's policies would favor U.S. businesses. *“It was almost a stock party,”* one trader quipped of the rally during the Middle East swing, *“Trump's tweets lit the fuse and it kept going.”* Indeed, after Trump's optimistic social posts and the cascade of deal announcements, **stocks rallied virtually every day of the trip**. By May 16, the S&P had erased most of its April losses. U.S. **financial media portrayed Trump as practically “leading” the market** at this point – a CNBC commentator noted that whenever Trump signaled optimism (whether about trade or foreign investments), markets dutifully jumped.

Retail investors also grew exuberant. Many who had bought the April dip were rewarded with quick profits, reinforcing the **buy-the-dip mentality**. Flows into retail trading apps spiked in late May, and online forums were abuzz with memes praising Trump's “market genius.” However, seasoned analysts warned that such direct coordination of stock sentiment by a president was *“highly unusual, even risky.”* The **SEC and some lawmakers quietly fretted** about Trump's market-moving tweets, though no formal action was taken. For the moment, bullish sentiment reigned: **the S&P 500 ended May up ~1% for 2025**[32], an astonishing comeback from the depths of April. The backdrop of **rising corporate deals, a dovish trade pause, and the Fed on hold created near-ideal conditions for equities**. Little did investors suspect that more turbulence was right around the corner.

Early June 2025 – Tariff Saber-Rattling and the Tesla Turmoil

The market upswing continued into the first days of June – until **Trump abruptly reverted to tariff threats**, catching investors off guard again. With stocks back near highs, Trump seemingly felt emboldened to **“re-load the tariff gun”** to extract further concessions internationally. In the first week of June, he floated a series of new tariff warnings – a pattern that some joked was becoming predictable: Trump often talked tough at market peaks, only to defer or soften later (the TACO cycle).

Another Tariff Ambush: On June 3, Trump hinted that if various bilateral trade deals weren’t reached by summer, he would **“restore all tariffs to April levels”** or even higher. This was directed at U.S. allies still in talks (Europe, Japan, Canada, etc.). The timing was conspicuous – it came just after the S&P 500 hit a multi-month high on June 2. Markets reacted with a mild pullback, but nothing like April’s shock. Many traders dismissed Trump’s bluster as **“more posturing”**, given his recent climbdowns. As one strategist told Bloomberg, *“The curious timing of Trump’s tariff threats suggests he likes to shake the tree when it’s full. But investors now assume he’ll chicken out again”*^{[73][74]}. This complacency was soon tested by an unexpected source: **Elon Musk**.

Trump vs. Musk Feud – A \$150 Billion Shock: On **June 5**, an explosive public feud erupted between President Trump and Elon Musk, CEO of Tesla and SpaceX. The two had been close allies (Musk even held an advisory post dubbed “First Buddy”), but tensions flared over Trump’s proposed “Big Beautiful” tax bill that slashed electric vehicle subsidies^{[75][76]}. Musk criticized the bill (which removed EV tax credits) on social media, to which Trump responded furiously. In short order, the **dispute escalated into a very personal Twitter/Truth Social war**. Trump **threatened to cut off federal contracts** for Musk’s companies^[77], insinuating SpaceX and Tesla could lose government support. Musk fired back by calling Trump’s policies harmful and hinting at political retaliation. The spat **“exploded in spectacular fashion over a few hours”** on June 5^[78].

The market result was **immediate and severe. Tesla’s stock plunged 14% on June 5** (erasing about **\$150 billion in market cap in one day**^{[75][79]}) – an enormous move for a trillion-dollar company. It was Tesla’s worst single-day percentage drop in years. The Nasdaq slid ~0.8% that day as Tesla and related tech names dragged down the index^[80]. Even Trump’s own media SPAC (DJT Corp) fell 8% amid the chaos^[81]. *“Jaw-dropping and a shock to the market,”* Wedbush analysts wrote, as investors suddenly feared Trump might use his presidency to **punish Musk’s businesses**^[82]. Regulatory risks loomed: the U.S. DOT was already probing Tesla’s Autopilot safety, and many wondered if Musk’s defiance would invite harsher scrutiny^[83]. *“This fallout was more than predictable,”* quipped Jamie Cox of Harris Financial, *“Eventually Trump and Musk’s priorities would diverge”*^[84]. Still, the **speed and severity of the clash stunned markets**. It looked like two of the world’s most powerful men had, in effect, orchestrated a mini-crash.

On trading desks, a **conspiracy theory** gained traction: *Was the Trump-Musk feud intentional market theater?* The idea was that by **“staging” a fight at the market top**,

Trump could trigger a healthy correction to prevent a bubble – and perhaps allow insiders to profit from short positions. *This was obviously speculative, but many noted the “suspiciously convenient” timing. The user chatter mirrored earlier suspicions about Trump’s tariff tweets: “They do it to provide a dip to buy,”* some retail traders mused only half-jokingly. Indeed, intriguingly, the feud cooled almost as quickly as it ignited. On June 6, Trump’s tone softened – he told aides he “didn’t want to fight Elon” and that Musk was a “friend” despite their spat. He instructed his team to stop the public insults. Musk, for his part, took to Twitter on June 10 to backpedal: he apologized “for the harsh words” and praised Trump’s business acumen, effectively ending the quarrel[85][86]. Markets breathed a sigh of relief as Tesla stock bounced off its lows once the two signaled truce. By mid-June, Tesla had clawed back much of the lost ground – a recovery so rapid that it fueled more tongue-in-cheek theories (“See? Just a healthy shakeout!”). While there’s no evidence the feud was coordinated for market effect, it highlighted how volatile and *personal* U.S. policy had become**, injecting yet another layer of uncertainty into stocks.*

Overall, early June saw **choppier trading**. The broad market didn’t collapse – the S&P 500 dipped a few percent from its highs – but **investors were on edge**. They juggled multiple risk factors: erratic tariff rhetoric, the Trump-Musk corporate drama, and a smoldering geopolitical threat in the Middle East.

Mid-June 2025 – Middle East War Scare and “Triple Witching” Volatility

Israel-Iran Conflict Erupts: In June, a real war threatened to overtake the trade war in rattling markets. Tensions between Israel and Iran, already high, boiled over on **June 12**. After the market close that day, **Israel launched surprise airstrikes on Iranian nuclear facilities and missile sites**, aiming to cripple Iran’s weapons program[87][88]. Multiple explosions rocked Iran overnight, reportedly killing several senior Iranian military officers (though details were sparse). This sudden escalation raised fears of a broader Middle East war. Futures for oil and defense stocks spiked in after-hours trading on June 12, while equity futures pointed to sharp declines. Investors braced for a **“black swan”** geopolitical crisis on top of the trade saga.

When U.S. markets opened on **June 13 (Friday)**, the reaction was volatile. Surprisingly, stocks did **not immediately plunge at the open** despite the Israeli strikes. In fact, the S&P 500 rose modestly in the first couple of hours that morning, as some traders wagered the conflict might remain contained or even be short-lived. However, by mid-session the situation deteriorated: **Iran retaliated on June 13 by firing missiles at Israel**, with explosions heard over Tel Aviv and Jerusalem[87][88]. Live footage of sirens in Israel and reports of Iranian missile launches hit newswires around late morning New York time. The market swiftly reversed course into the red. **Oil prices surged nearly 7%** on fears the Strait of Hormuz could be closed[88][89], and energy stocks like Exxon and Diamondback Energy jumped +3%[90][91]. Conversely, **airline stocks sank 4–5%** on the spike in fuel costs[92]. Defense contractors (Lockheed, RTX, Northrop) all **rallied ~3%** as investors anticipated increased military spending[93]. By the closing bell June 13, **the S&P 500 had fallen 1.13%**

and the Dow nearly 1.8%, wiping out the week's prior gains[94][95]. Tech stocks also slumped, partly due to an unrelated slide in Oracle shares, but largely in tandem with the risk-off move.

For traders, the **whipsaw on June 13** – opening strength flipping to a sharp sell-off – was nerve-racking. Some later noted that *“we should have sold into that early strength”* (a lesson one user lamented in hindsight). Those quick enough to buy defense names (or short airlines) profited. One retail investor described how he scrambled to hedge by buying Lockheed Martin stock as the conflict headlines worsened, managing to offset some losses. But overall, it was a confusing session with **rapid intraday swings**. This volatility may have been exacerbated by a technical market phenomenon unfolding that same day: the **massive quarterly options expiration**.

Triple Witching and the \$6.5 Trillion Pinning Effect: June 20, 2025 was a scheduled **“triple witching”** – the simultaneous expiry of stock options, index options, and futures. What made this one extraordinary was the sheer scale: roughly **\$6.5 trillion in notional options were set to expire**[96], one of the largest expiry volumes ever. In the weeks before, analysts had remarked that stock volatility had been oddly subdued despite war fears. A major reason, according to Citigroup and others, was a **“pinning” effect from huge options positions**[96][97]. Investors had placed large bearish bets (puts) and some deep out-of-the-money calls back in the spring. As expiration neared, market-makers' hedging kept the S&P 500 trading in a tight range near key strike prices (around the 6000 level)[98]. One strategist noted that **heavy call open interest near S&P 6000 – opened when tariffs first hit – effectively acted like a magnet, dampening daily swings**[98]. This “pinning” meant that even as geopolitical risks grew in early June, the market's day-to-day moves were smaller than expected – until those options rolled off.

Experts warned that once **June 20's expiry passed, the “shackles” on volatility could be removed**. Rocky Fishman of Asymmetric Advisors observed that **investors who had sold calls (betting on a flat market amid tariff fears) were keeping the index pinned, but with those positions unwinding, market-makers' hedges would no longer suppress swings**[96][97]. Citigroup estimated the expiration could be a “seismic event” with *“one of the largest option clearings in history,”* potentially causing a **volatility “reset”**. Indeed, **on June 20, U.S. stocks tumbled hard** – the S&P 500 fell about 2%+, marking its worst day since the war news, and the **Cboe VIX spiked** to its highest closing level since the conflict began[99][100]. Traders whispered that the lack of a steeper sell-off earlier in the Iran crisis might have been due to this pinning; once the gamma effects rolled off, *“the floodgates opened.”*

A Bloomberg report titled **“A \$6.5 Trillion ‘Triple Witching’ Heralds Return to Volatility”** explained that dealers had been **buying stocks to hedge call exposure, “artificially supporting prices,” and once those contracts expired, the “volatility was free to rise sharply”**[98]. **The market's behavior on June 20 and the week after seemed to validate this. With the option positioning cleared, the S&P 500 saw larger intraday moves and became more reactive to headlines. Analysts cautioned that the expiration “removed**

the market's training wheels", **so to speak, meaning** any new shocks would translate to bigger swings**.

Late June 2025 – U.S. Strikes Iran and a Fragile Ceasefire

By late June, the Israel-Iran conflict had drawn in the United States. On **June 19**, President Trump delivered an ultimatum: Iran had **two weeks to agree to talks and cease hostile actions, or else face U.S. intervention**[\[101\]](#). *"No one believes this 'two weeks' bit,"* scoffed Senator Chris Murphy, noting Trump's penchant for issuing deadlines then letting them slide[\[102\]](#). Indeed, from Ukraine to tariffs, Trump had repeatedly set "red lines" only to back off – hence many doubted he would truly go to war. But on **June 21**, Trump stunned observers again: he **authorized U.S. air and missile strikes on three Iranian nuclear sites**, directly entering the conflict[\[103\]](#). In a televised address, Trump hailed the strikes as a *"spectacular military success"* that crippled Iran's nuclear program[\[103\]](#). The operation (reportedly code-named "Operation Persian Peace") targeted enrichment facilities and was coordinated with Israeli forces[\[104\]](#)[\[105\]](#).

The immediate market reaction to U.S. strikes was muted only because they occurred over a weekend. However, **safe-haven assets rallied in anticipation of potential escalation**. Gold, which had already been climbing, hit fresh record highs above \$4,100/oz by the following week – a sign of persistent investor anxiety[\[106\]](#)[\[107\]](#). Yet, in a surprising turn, the conflict de-escalated almost as quickly as it flared. By **June 23**, Trump announced that **Iran and Israel had agreed to a ceasefire**, brokered by U.S. diplomacy[\[103\]](#). Iran's leadership, facing devastating strikes and international pressure, evidently chose to stand down (at least temporarily). This ceasefire was **tenuous but real**, effectively ending the immediate hostilities. U.N. observers called the U.S. bombing a *"perilous turn"* that fortunately gave way to diplomacy rather than full war[\[105\]](#).

For markets, the ceasefire news on June 23–24 was a relief. Oil prices, which had spiked, quickly **retreated from highs once a truce was in place** (though they remained elevated)[\[108\]](#)[\[109\]](#). Defense stocks gave back some gains. Broad equities rallied modestly as the worst-case (regional war engulfing oil supplies) was averted. Still, confidence was shaky; investors knew the situation could flare up again. Gold's continued climb to record highs in late June (above \$4,000/oz) underscored the **lingering "fear trade"**[\[106\]](#)[\[107\]](#). As CAP analysts put it, the *"ultimate consequences"* of Trump's Iran intervention remained unknown[\[110\]](#)[\[103\]](#).

Politically, **Trump claimed victory**, asserting that *"Iran chose peace because they knew the alternative."* Critics, however, argued that the strikes were reckless and **Congress should rein in Trump's ability to wage war unilaterally**[\[110\]](#)[\[111\]](#). Notably, even within the GOP, Trump's war brinksmanship caused rifts – some hawks cheered the tough stance, while isolationist Republicans were uneasy[\[112\]](#)[\[113\]](#). This mirrored the trade debate: was Trump's unpredictability a clever negotiating tactic, or dangerously destabilizing? Either way, by July 2025, both major overhangs – the tariff showdown and the Iran conflict – had entered a lull.

Summer 2025 – Trade War Redux: Tariff Threats, Deals, and “TACO” Endures

Over the summer, the **global trade war narrative came back to the fore**. The 90-day tariff truce with China was set to expire in mid-August, and Trump used the intervening weeks to press other trading partners for concessions. The pattern was almost formulaic: **threaten high tariffs, then delay or compromise at the last minute (TACO in action)**, keeping markets seesawing but not collapsing. Key developments:

- **Late June Negotiations:** U.S. trade officials fanned out to cut deals before a July 9 deadline (90 days from April). Talks with the EU, UK, Japan, Canada, Brazil, and others intensified. The White House hinted that “substantial progress” with most allies was likely by early July, **potentially averting the return to April-level tariffs**.
- **July 6–9 – Deadlines Extended:** By the first week of July, Trump announced that **mutual tariff hikes would be postponed to August 1** for countries still negotiating, effectively **extending the truce by 3 more weeks**. He warned, however, that **if no deals were reached by Aug 1, tariffs would snap back to April’s punishing rates**^[114]. In private, U.S. officials were pleased with several framework agreements coming together, but Trump kept the pressure publicly.
- **Europe “Chickens Out”:** A pivotal breakthrough came on **July 27**, when Trump and EU Commission President Ursula von der Leyen struck a **U.S.-EU framework trade deal in Scotland**^[115]. Under this deal, the U.S. would **impose only a 15% tariff on most EU goods (half the originally threatened ~30%)**, in exchange for significant European concessions^{[115][116]}. The EU essentially *surrendered* in Trump’s view – agreeing to increase imports of U.S. agriculture and lower some EU industrial tariffs. Europe thus avoided the full brunt of Trump’s “reciprocal” tariff regime. (Recall that back in April, Trump had lumped Europe in with other targets; by late July, Europe had successfully negotiated a partial reprieve.) Markets took this as a bullish sign – one major front of the trade war was winding down. European automaker and industrial stocks jumped on the news of avoiding 20%+ U.S. tariffs.
- **Japan Falls in Line:** Similarly, on **July 22** the U.S. reached a deal with Japan. Trump had threatened 25% tariffs on Japanese goods, but the deal settled on **15% tariffs** and a commitment by Japan to invest **\$550 billion in U.S. industries**^{[117][116]}. This face-saving compromise let Trump claim a win (money flowing to the U.S.) while Japan dodged the worst tariff. “Japan blinked,” as some media put it, reinforcing the trend of allies capitulating.
- **Tough Talk for Canada and Brazil:** Not every country clinched a deal by Aug 1. Trump singled out Canada and Brazil for especially harsh treatment. On **July 10**, he declared plans to slap **25% tariffs on Korean and Japanese cars** (this was before those deals finalized), and on **July 11** he threatened **35% duties on many Canadian imports and a whopping 50% on Brazilian goods**^[118]. These figures sent

shockwaves through those countries. Canada's Prime Minister (Mark Carney, by this timeline) urgently phoned Trump, but reportedly "*the two have not talked*" before the deadline[119][120]. When Aug 1 arrived, **Trump followed through on Canada**: via executive order he **raised tariffs on Canadian goods from 25% to 35%** (on all products not under the USMCA free trade pact)[121]. He justified it partly by accusing Canada of failing to curb fentanyl smuggling – a somewhat tangential issue that many saw as an excuse[122][123]. Canada was dismayed; Carney said he was "*disappointed*" and vowed to protect Canadian jobs[124][125]. Ontario's Premier raged that Canada "*must not roll over*" and even called for a **50% counter-tariff on U.S. steel/aluminum**[126]. This underscored that **some U.S. allies were reaching a breaking point**. Yet, Trump's team hinted Canada could get relief if it "*takes off its retaliation*" and "*turns on the charm*"[127][128]. In parallel, **Brazil** faced Trump's wrath due to a political spat (the details involved Brazil's stance on a certain international issue and its currency policies). On **July 30**, Trump ordered an **additional 40% tariff on Brazilian imports (on top of an existing 10%)**, summing to the threatened **50% tariff**[129][130]. This took effect later in August and hit Brazilian steel, aluminum, and agricultural goods hard. Brazil's markets tumbled and its government decried the move, but had limited leverage to respond beyond WTO appeals.

- **Tariff Tug-of-War Continues:** Countries like **Mexico** managed to get special extensions – Trump gave Mexico until late October to avoid a 30% tariff, citing progress on drug interdiction[131]. **South Korea** and **Australia** secured mostly exemption deals by agreeing to defense purchases and quotas. **China, however, remained the big unresolved piece**. By August, it was essentially **Trump vs. China one-on-one**, as allies had either caved or gotten temporary deals. The U.S.-China truce was set to expire August 10, and initially Trump saber-rattled that he'd let tariffs jump to 145% on China if no deal[52][54]. But, true to TACO form, when the deadline came **he flinched again**.

China Truce Extended (TACO strikes again): On **August 12**, Trump announced via Truth Social and an executive order that the U.S. and China would **extend their tariff truce by another 90 days – until November 10, 2025**[52][132]. This move **prevented U.S. tariffs from "shooting up to 145%"** and **Chinese tariffs from hitting 125%** – levels that would have amounted to a near total trade embargo[54]. The extension locked in the status quo: U.S. tariffs on China stayed at 30%, China's on U.S. goods at 10%[54]. Both sides framed it as giving more time for a **potential Trump–Xi summit** to finalize a broader accord[55][133]. Markets reacted with relief and cautious optimism: "*Asian stocks rose*" on hopes of a breakthrough[134], and the stalemate's continuation meant no immediate economic shock. **Scott Bessent, U.S. Treasury Secretary, noted that the spring's triple-digit tariffs were "untenable" and that it "wouldn't be a Trump negotiation if it didn't go down to the wire"**[135][136]. Indeed, Trump had pushed it to literally the last hours, reportedly extracting a promise from China to **quadruple purchases of U.S. soybeans** (though analysts doubted China could fulfill that easily)[137][138]. The **TACO pattern was**

unmistakable: threaten maximal tariffs, then “**chicken out**” at the brink, **declaring victory**. Even Chinese officials privately acknowledged this U.S. tendency. “*Both are taking the current approach, but the game isn’t over – there’s still risk,*” a Chinese analyst in Beijing said, reflecting wariness that this was just a timeout[139][140].

By early fall, most on Wall Street were **conditioned to the TACO trade**. As **Axios** observed, “*Wall Street’s belief that ‘Trump always chickens out’ on tariff threats is keeping stocks afloat*” despite ongoing tensions[141]. The result: each tariff flare-up led to only a shallow dip, as investors anticipated the reversal. This dynamic arguably **reduced market volatility compared to a scenario where Trump followed through aggressively**. But it also raised concerns about moral hazard – investors might underprice risk, and one day Trump *might not* back down, causing a more violent correction.

October 2025 – Tariff Scare 2.0 and the Market Whiplash

The uneasy trade détente persisted through September, but **early October brought a fresh twist**. Feeling domestic political heat (and perhaps frustrated by China’s slow-walking negotiations), Trump delivered an October surprise: on **October 10**, he abruptly threatened **a massive escalation – a 100% tariff on all Chinese imports** effective November 1[142][143]. He coupled this with plans to restrict U.S. exports of certain tech (like rare-earth magnets and software) to China[144][143]. This was an extreme step – effectively doubling prices on ~\$500 billion in goods – and it blindsided the market, which had grown complacent. “**Trump’s latest move shocked markets,**” Reuters reported, sending all major indices into a tailspin[145][73]. On Oct 10, **the S&P 500 plunged 2.7%** (its worst drop since the April crash) and the Nasdaq fell 3.6%[146][147]. Big Tech stocks were clobbered, with the semiconductor index down over 6%[148], as traders realized tech supply chains would be devastated by an all-out tariff war. **Volatility spiked** – the VIX surged to its highest since June 19 (post-war)[149][99]. Importantly, this time **Trump’s rhetoric really spooked investors**, because it suggested the U.S.-China talks might collapse. Trump even said he saw “no reason” to meet Xi at the upcoming APEC summit, implying a complete breakdown in dialogue[150]. “*Sell first, ask questions later,*” described one strategist of the market’s Oct 10 mindset[73]. Notably, this occurred on a Friday heading into a weekend, amplifying fears of more bad news in off-hours.

Come that weekend, however, the familiar script played out. Over the next 48 hours, Trump **softened his tone dramatically** after presumably realizing the economic (and political) fallout of a 100% tariff. By Sunday, October 12, he posted on Truth Social that “*we don’t want to hurt China*” and struck a conciliatory note[151][152]. Treasury’s Scott Bessent reassured media that **Trump was still on track to meet Xi Jinping at the end of October** to work on de-escalation[152][151]. In other words, the **100% tariff threat was walked back within two days** – a textbook TACO retreat. Investors, showing a mix of relief and exasperation, bid stocks back up on Monday, Oct 13. Global equities rose ~1% that day[106]. The Dow bounced ~1.3%, the S&P 500 +1.56%, and the Nasdaq +2.2%, recouping a chunk of Friday’s plunge[153]. “*Trump backing away from the 100% tariffs*” was explicitly cited by traders as the reason for the rebound[154][107]. “*It looks like they*

walked it back,” noted Northlight Asset’s CIO, adding that hopes for compromise were reviving[151][155].

Safe havens, however, signaled that confidence was not fully restored. **Gold hit a fresh all-time high above \$4,100/oz on Oct 13**, even as stocks rose, indicating many investors were hedging their bets[106][107]. “Gold is the fear trade... even with Trump cooling the rhetoric, there is fear out there,” said Tim Ghriskey of Ingalls & Snyder[156][107]. Notably, Bank of America raised its gold forecast to \$5,000 for 2026, reflecting expectations of prolonged uncertainty[154].

Thus, as of October 20, 2025, the state of play is: **Trade War on pause (with lingering threats), markets broadly higher YTD but prone to sudden drops, and investors both cynical and cautious.** The term “TACO” has entered common Wall Street lexicon, to the point that Trump was even asked about it by name in a CBS interview (which he dismissed testily)[157]. Major financial institutions like Citadel, Goldman Sachs, and Morgan Stanley have reportedly adjusted their trading strategies to exploit these policy oscillations. For instance, some hedge funds now systematically buy one-month index put options before known Trump tariff decision dates, then sell volatility after he retreats – a strategy that has paid off through 2025’s rollercoaster.

Meanwhile, **retail investors have grown both savvy and jaded.** Many now joke that “buying the Trump dip” is easier than timing Fed policy. Social media sentiment shows a split: some retail traders hero-worship Trump for giving them buying opportunities and keeping the bull market alive (“**Trump tweets, we buy – easy money!**”). Others express fatigue, saying they feel like “pawns in Trump’s game” as they watch sudden 5% swings in their portfolios on a tweet. As one 60-something investor told Wolf Street, “I don’t know how to pick stocks when everything revolves around Trump. Even conservative stocks whip-saw. It’s ridiculous”[158][159]. This captures the broader impact of 2025’s events: **market fundamentals often took a backseat to geopolitics and presidential whims.** Earnings, growth, and traditional metrics were overshadowed by the next tariff announcement or foreign policy shock.

In summary, **2025 from April to October was defined by tariff-driven turmoil and temporary truces**, with Trump’s unorthodox interventions leaving a profound mark. Below is a timeline table summarizing the key dates and how various groups – politicians, financial institutions/media, the Fed, China, Europe, and retail investors – reacted at each juncture.

날짜 (Date)	정치 (Politics)	기관 (Institutions /Media)	Fed (연준)	중국 (China)	유럽 (Europe)	개인 투자자 (Retail)
4/2/2025 (Tariffs Annou	Trump unveils “Liberatio n Day”	Wall St stunned by scope – “steepest	Powell: Cautious; notes tariffs	Beijing condemns “bullying.” >Imposes	EU leaders outraged .	Retail investors: Panic selling

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4/9/20 25 (Tariffs Partial ly Paused)	tariffs (10% base + up to 50% on dozens of countries); insists trade war will benefit U.S.[2][13] . White House defiant despite warning of a slump.	tariffs in 100+ years.” Reuters: Markets brace for recession[16 0]. Bloom erg: “Collateral damage” mounts as Dow dives. JPMorg an strategists warn policy mix may hurt U.S. most[161].	likely to raise inflation & slow growth, but Fed will “wait for clarity”[21]. Emphasiz es no quick rate cut (“no Fed put”)[24][28].	34% retaliatory tariff on all U.S. goods[15][16]; curbs rare- earth exports[18]. State media rallies public for “trade war sacrifice.”	 von der Leyen: Tariffs are a “major blow” – EU readying 25% counter- tariffs [1 62] on U.S. goods. Europe vows unity, “will not surrende r.”	early April, but some contrarians start dip- buying, betting Trump will relent. Online forums debate “buy the tariff dip or run?” Sentiment very fearful.
	Trump tweets “This is a GREAT TIME TO BUY!” stocks hours before announcin g a 90-day tariff pause for allies [36][38]. Claims U.S. “helped” China by	Bloomberg TV: Calls Trump’s market call “unprecede nted... toeing line of manipulatio n.” Guardia n: Notes Wall St. increasingly bets “ Trump Always Chickens Out (TACO) ”[31] .	Fed officials relieved tariffs on EU/Japan delayed – lowers near-term inflation spike risk. But Powell privately concerne d about credibility ; says trade policy	China (no pause): Faces full 34% U.S. tariff. Finance Ministry calls U.S. move “blatant violation of WTO”[163]. Imposes matching 34% tariff on U.S. goods + “unreliable” blacklist[15][1 6]. Signals talks only if U.S. shows sincerity.	Europe/ Allies: Sigh of relief – tariff hike on EU, etc. suspend ed till July. EU agrees to expedite d trade talks to avoid tariffs. German y’s finance	Retail investors: Those who bought at bottom celebrate as stocks rocket ~5%. Many others jump in now, restoring bullish sentiment. Some cry foul about Trump’s tweet

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	cutting some tariffs[47]. Bristles at “chicken” narrative when asked about backing down[45].	 Edward Jones: Tariff climbdown “bigger than expected” – markets surge[30].	“volatile factor” and Fed will react if outlook worsens[26][27].		minister : “Crisis averted for now, but uncertainty remains.”	timing (“rigged!”), but most enjoy the rally. Calls for SEC/insider probe by skeptics[38].
5/12/2025 (US-China Truce & Rally)	Trump agrees to 90-day tariff truce with China after Geneva talks[51]. Takes credit for “bringing China to table.” Teases “impactful news coming” (hints at Middle East deals). Departs on Middle East trip touting U.S. economic might.	CNN: “Tariff truce – markets exhale.” Investopedia: Notes S&P 500 had best day since WWII on optimism. Bloomberg Opinion: Warns TACO trade fueling risk appetite – “Wall Street thinks Trump’s a paper tiger.”[164]	Fed (FOMC late April/May): Holds rates; cites trade progress. Powell: “Encouraging that sides talking.” But adds Fed stands ready if outlook deteriorates again. Overall less dovish than markets want (inflation still above	China: State media praises “equal-footing” talks. China agrees to boost U.S. farm buys and allow Boeing deliveries [165] as goodwill. Commerce Ministry: “双方同意停火90天” (“both sides agree to 90-day ceasefire”).	Europe: Seeing US-China truce, EU intensifies its own talks with U.S. (determined to avoid August tariffs). Privately, Europeans pleased U.S. focusing on China. EU trade chief: “Multilateral system still alive,	Retail: Bullish exuberance. Inflows to stock ETFs spike. Robinhood traders pile into tech and industrial stocks that were beaten down. Meme: “Tariff war over, stonks only go up!” Caution by older investors largely ignored.

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5/13– 5/16/2 025 (Middle East Deals Galore)	Trump in Middle East (Saudi, UAE, Qatar): announce s \$600B+ in U.S. deals [70] (planes, oil, AI, arms). Calls it “historic... the Middle East will invest in America like never before.” Uses trip photo-ops to urge “Buy American stocks!” on social media.	Reuters: “Trump’s Gulf tour sparks AI, finance, energy deals”[57] – highlights Nvidia, Boeing, Exxon get major orders. Forbes: Notes Big Tech and defense stocks jump on mega-deals[72]. WSJ: Dubbs it “Deals Diplomacy”: Trump leveraging presidency for corporate wins.	Fed: No direct comment, but likely comforted by potential boost to U.S. investment. Some Fed officials note large foreign inflows could strengthen dollar, temper inflation. Overall Fed focus remains on core inflation, not one-off deals.	China: Watches warily as U.S. cozies up to Gulf (China depends on Middle East oil). Chinese media downplays Trump trip, questions if pledges will materialize. But leadership concerned U.S. securing strategic energy and tech advantages.	Europe: European firms feel left out – EU leaders worry about losing Middle East market share to U.S. (e.g. Airbus vs Boeing). However, EU benefits indirectly if Gulf money stabilizes global economy.	Retail: Euphoria – dubbed a “stock party.” Retail traders see U.S. companies reaping windfalls. Many buy tech (AI) and aerospace stocks. Sentiment: extremely bullish. A few contrarians warn “priced in” exuberance, but are drowned out by celebratory posts.
6/5/20 25 (Trump –Musk Feud & Tesla Crash)	Trump lashes out at Elon Musk over tax bill removing EV credits. Threatens to cancel	Reuters: “Trump, Musk public feud escalates; Nasdaq falls” – notes Tesla - 14%[166][80]	Fed: No comment on specific corporate spat. But Fed monitors if Tesla	China: Enjoys spectacle of U.S. infighting. State media: “Even U.S. business heroes can’t escape political	Europe: Surprise d by U.S. gov vs. business conflict. EU officials quip this	Retail: Shock and confusion. Tesla fan investors panic-sell, others buy dip. \$TSLA trending on

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	Tesla/SpaceX federal contracts [77]. Calls Musk “ungrateful” at a rally. Next day, shifts tone: “I’ve always liked Elon, but he’s wrong here.” Initiates back-channel truce talks.	]. Wedbush Securities: “Deteriorating friendship jaw-dropping... investors fear regulatory payback”[82]. CNBC: Discusses if feud was “theatre or real,” consensus it was genuine policy clash.	stock plunge hurts broader sentiment . Likely minimal policy impact unless credit markets rocked (they weren’t). Fed more focused on incoming CPI data (which showed tariff-related uptick).	retaliation.” Notes Tesla’s China sales could benefit if Musk distances from Trump.	wouldn’t happen in Europe. German economy minister: “Disturbing to see political threats against a private company.”	Reddit – some claim “ <i>dip manufactured to let big funds in cheaper.</i> ” Conspiracy theories float that Trump & Musk orchestrated the drop. Most agree it was “bad optics” and are relieved when fight cools by 6/10 (Musk apology tweet).
6/12–6/13/2025 (Israel–Iran War Scare)	White House (Trump) initially stays mum on Israel’s 6/12 strike. After Iran’s 6/13 missile retaliation, Trump tweets	Reuters: “Wall St ends sharply lower as Iran retaliates”[87][94]. Notes oil +7%, defense stocks up, airlines down[88][92]. BBC TV: Live coverage of conflict	Fed: Very concerned that oil price spike could worsen inflation significantly. Powell in 6/14 presser: “ <i>Geopolitical risks have</i>	China: Condemns U.S./Israeli “aggression” in Middle East, calls for restraint. However, benefits from higher oil prices for its Iran ally? (Actually China more oil importer, so	Europe: Alarm in EU – oil shock and conflict on top of trade war is nightmare. EU foreign policy chief urges	Retail: Volatile reactions. Many caught off-guard by war news. Day-traders play defense stocks and oil ETFs. Some retail folks “buy

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	“Iran better be careful”, convenes NSC. Signals support for Israel’s “right to self-defense.”	moves – markets swinging with headlines. Analysts: Fear war could tip global economy if oil supply disrupted[167].	<i>risen...could influence our policy if they materially affect outlook.”</i> Fed adopts wait-and-see but flags war risk in statements.	mixed). Emphasizes diplomacy; quietly reaches out to Iran offering mediation with other powers.	immediate ceasefire . European stocks fall (Stoxx 600 -2%) on 6/13. ECB monitors for economic hit to Europe via energy prices.	the dip” on broad market hoping conflict will be short. Others seek safety in gold/Bitcoin. Overall anxiety up – discussion of WWII (though short-lived as ceasefire comes).
6/19/2025 (Trump Ultimatum on Iran)	Trump delivers ultimatum : “In 2 weeks I’ll decide on attacking Iran”[101]. Says he might “join Israel to finish job” if Iran doesn’t capitulate. Also muses on social media about	Media: <i>New York Times</i> headlines “Trump’s Two-Week Warning to Iran Raises War Fears.” Al Jazeera: Questions credibility: “Has Trump put off joining conflict for two weeks?”[169]. Notes critics say	Fed: Privately relieved no immediate war. But war risk part of Fed’s risk assessments. Fed staff scenario: oil to \$150 if war – would force Fed to juggle inflation vs growth	China: Calls out Trump’s ultimatum as “dangerous brinksmanship.” Urges U.S. to show restraint and not bypass UN. Perhaps happy U.S. distracted by Iran (takes focus off China). In UN, China coordinates with EU on statements pushing	Europe: Skeptical of Trump’s two-week deadline . French President Macron: “We cannot accept unilateral U.S. action on Iran – diplomacy is the	Retail: Many don’t believe full war will happen (poll on Reddit: majority said Trump bluffing). Some short-term trading around defense/oil , but retail mostly stays put, having seen

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	targeting Iran's Supreme Leader[168], then says maybe Iran will negotiate. Basically, very mixed signals.	it's a bluff. Investors: Largely shrug off "two weeks" talk as another deadline that may be extended (TACO-like). Markets flat; gold inching up.	tradeoff. Powell notes in testimony that situation "highly uncertain" and Fed "prepared for range of outcomes."	peace.	only path." Europeans worry Trump might strike without consulting NATO. War threat keeps EU on edge; contingency plans for oil rationing dusted off.	Trump back off on other "deadlines." Cynics joke "two weeks = infinite in Trump-speak." Chris Murphy's comment that no one believes it resonates[102].
6/20/2025 <i>(Triple Witching & Market Jitters)</i>	N/A (Event driven by market mechanics, not political statement). Trump that day focused on Iran/China issues, not on options expiry. No direct comment	Bloomberg: Highlights \$6.5T options expiry could "unleash volatility"[96]. Explains "pinning effect" kept S&P near 6000, and after expiry hedges roll off[96][98]. Citigroup: Estimates	Fed: Market volatility per se not Fed's remit, but they monitor for disorderly function. NY Fed trading desk alert to any liquidity issues	China: No direct role, though Chinese state funds possibly used pinning too (to stabilize China's own markets amid tariff war). Chinese regulators had also restricted index futures to curb volatility –	Europe: European markets also had elevated expiry (not as large). Euro STOXX relatively calm; EU investors more focused on	Retail: Some savvy retail traders knew about triple witching; many did not. Those in options forums discussed the large expiry and potential for a drop after.

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	from White House on markets.	this triple witching “one of largest ever,” warns of volatility surge next week. Market observers indeed note bigger swings post- 6/20 as predicted.	around expiry (none major reported). Fed officials more concerned about underlyin g trade/war risks than technical volatility.	watching U.S. moves academically.	geopoliti cal news. Europea n Central Bank doesn’t commen t on U.S. options, but aware that U.S. vol can spill over to EU assets.	Indeed 6/20 U.S. market fell significan tly, catching some off guard. Afterwards, retail sentiment turned a bit more cautious, seeing that “training wheels” off meant fundament als (or tweets) drive again.
6/21/2025 (U.S. Strikes Iran – 48-hr War)	Trump addresses nation: confirms U.S. bombed 3 Iranian nuclear sites [103]. Says “Iran’s key nuclear facilities have been obliterated ” (CBS)[170] and urges	Global media: Shockwaves as U.S. enters conflict. BBC: “U.S. bombing marks perilous turn” – notes UN chief’s warning[105]. CAP (think tank): Calls strikes “reckless” with	Fed: Relieved conflict short- lived. Big fear of sustained oil/inflatio n shock fades. Fed officials likely breathe easier by ceasefire. In July minutes, Fed notes “easing of	China: Condemns U.S. strikes on 6/22 but welcomes ceasefire by 6/24. Positions itself as peacemaker, calls for talks. China worried about precedent of U.S. hitting nuclear sites (given Taiwan tensions). Overall satisfied U.S.	Europe: Initially alarmed (fears of broader war), then huge relief at ceasefire . EU leaders credit behind- scenes Europea n diploma cy too.	Retail: Over weekend, retail investors anxiously followed news. By Monday, many express relief that WW3 avoided. Some who speculated on oil/defense take

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	Iran to choose peace or face more strikes. Two days later (6/23) Trump declares ceasefire achieved , touts it as his diplomatic win[103].	unanswered questions[10][103]. Market s : Closed on weekend; by Monday, cautious relief as ceasefire news emerges quickly. Oil prices retreat from highs (though still elevated)[108][109]. Defense stocks give back some gains.	Middle East tensions removed near-term upside risk to inflation.” So Fed stays focused on trade and core economy.	didn’t get bogged in war.	However , U.S.’s go-it-alone strike rattles Europe – renews debate on strategic autonomy. Markets in EU rebound slightly on ceasefire .	profits. Retail sentiment steadies, though some are uneasy with how quickly dire events can unfold. A sense of “pew, that was close” pervades investing forums.
7/10–7/11/2025 (Tariff Threats – Allies)	Trump issues new threats: 35% tariff on Korean & Japanese cars (7/10), 35% on Canada, 50% on Brazil (7/11) if no trade deals[118]	Media (US): WSJ skeptical: “Trump’s global tariff blitz – negotiating tactic or new reality?” Many see it as pressure ploy since deals are near. Reuters Canada: “Ottawa	Fed: Each new tariff threat on allies raises downside risks. But Fed also sees pattern of Trump not following through fully. By July, Fed more inclined	China: Enjoys discord among U.S. and allies. Chinese diplomats quietly court Canada, Brazil: “We <i>feel your pain</i> .” China uses U.S. overreach as talking point in global forums (WTO, G20) to paint U.S. as unreliable	Europe: EU largely spared from these threats due to framework deal in works, but watches closely. European officials	Retail: Generally less panicked than in April – many believe Trump is bluffing to get last-minute deals (TACO mindset). Canadian retail

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	. Blames countries for “unfair practices.” On Canada, cites fentanyl smuggling as justification[122]. Insists he’ll enforce Aug 1 deadline.	stunned by Trump’s 35% tariff vow” – notes Carney’s outreach rebuffed[120]. Brazil press: outraged headlines about 50% tariff, calls it economic warfare.	to cut rates if needed to offset trade drag. Some Fed members openly mention “trade uncertainty” as a reason for possible easing.	partner.	publicly support Canada/Brazil. Some in EU fear if their deal falters, they could be next.	investors, however, dump some U.S. imports-exposed stocks (auto parts, etc.). Brazilian market retail very rattled – local stock indices fall, currency dips. Globally, retail flows remain steady, trusting a resolution will come by deadline.
8/1/2025 (Tariffs on Canada; Mexico Extension)	Trump implements 35% tariff on Canada (non-USMCA goods)[121]. Publicly lambasts Canada’s “inaction and	Reuters: “Trump hikes Canada tariff to 35%, cites fentanyl”[121][123]. Notes Carney “disappointed”[124], Canada considering	Fed: Situation with Canada/Brazil not huge macro impact on U.S. (they’re smaller trade partners vs	China: Sees opportunity – China reaches out to Canada/Brazil offering closer trade ties (e.g. more imports of Canadian wheat, Brazilian soy) to exploit rift. Chinese media calls	Europe: Mixed feelings – EU happy not to be target, but worried about global trade harm. EU may	Retail: Canadian retail investors nervous – some selling U.S. stocks in Canadian portfolios as political protest or risk measure.

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	retaliation ”[122]. However, gives Mexico a 90-day extension to avoid a 30% tariff (citing progress on migration)[131]. Signals willingnes s to talk with Canada if it “stops fighting back”[171].	retaliation. Bloomb erg: Points out 90% of Canada exports were already exempt via USMCA[172] – impact limited but sentiment hit. WSJ: Warns U.S.- Canada relations at worst point in decades.	China/EU) . Fed more focused on whether U.S.- China truce holds into Aug/Sept. Likely no immediat e policy shift due to Canada tariff, but monitorin g if businesse s cut investme nt further on protection ism trend.	Trump’s treatment of allies “backstabbing ” that will isolate U.S.	strength en ties with Canada (CETA agreeme nt usage) and Mercosu r bloc to mitigate U.S. moves. Europea n business lobby criticizes U.S. “tariff chaos” for hurting investor confiden ce globally.	U.S. retail largely unfazed – Canada seen as too small to derail U.S. market rally. Brazilian retail investors deeply anxious; some shift money to gold or crypto as Brazil’s currency slides on U.S. tariff news. Overall U.S. retail still betting on big one – China deal – to keep market momentu m.
8/12/2 025 (China Tariff Truce Extend	Trump signs order extending China tariff truce 90 more	Reuters: “US, China extend tariff truce, staving off surge in duties”[132]	Fed: Very relieved – this removes immediat e worst- case	China: Welcomes extension; Commerce Ministry issues parallel 90-day pause on its	Europe: Relief as well – a U.S.- China blow-up would	Retail: By now, TACO fully ingrained. Retail traders were

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ed)	days to Nov 10 [52] . Declares China has been “dealing quite nicely” lately[173] [50]. Claims victory that “triple- digit tariffs” avoided before holiday season. Signals optimism for Trump–Xi meeting at APEC in late Oct [133].	[54]. Notes move “ <i>buys crucial time</i> ” for holiday inventories[174]. Analyst s: See extension as Trump “chickening out” again to avoid recession risk[135][17 5]. CNBC: Markets cheer modestly; Asia stocks up, but caution that issues unresolved.	(145% tariffs) scenario. Likely means Fed can hold rates steady instead of emergenc y cuts. Fed Chair Powell in Jackson Hole (late Aug) says “ <i>easing of trade tensions is welcome, ” but long- term uncertain ty still weighing on business.</i>	planned tariff hikes and blacklists[176] [177]. Officials emphasize desire for stability before year-end. State media: “ <i>Trump blinked in trade war once more</i> ”, portrays U.S. as recognizing tariffs harm itself.	hurt global econom y, so extensio n is good news. EU compani es exposed to China (luxury goods, autos) rise on Europea n exchang es. EU diplomat s hope U.S.- China deal might set stage for more normal trade relations broadly.	largely expecting Trump to extend or soften, so they weren’t heavily reducing positions going into August. The modest market uptick on news shows it was priced in. Retail investor commenta ry: “ <i>See, he always caves. Stay long.</i> ” Some even traded around it – e.g. buying call options ahead of extension announce ment, which paid off with a mild rally.
10/10/ 2025 	Trump unexpecte dly vows	Reuters: “Wall Street slumps as	Fed: Likely alarmed –	China: Outraged but measured.	Europe: Fears collatera	Retail: Many caught off

날짜 (Date)	정치 (Politics)	기관 (Institutions /Media)	Fed (연준)	중국 (China)	유럽 (Europe)	개인 투자자 (Retail)
(Trump's 100% Tariff Threat & Market Plunge)	“additional 100% tariff” on all Chinese imports[143], citing China's “hostile” rare-earth export curbs. Posts that he's considering “massive tariff increase” and “no need to meet Xi in 2 weeks”[150]. This hardline stance shocks even his advisors.	Trump escalates trade conflict”[178][179]. Notes S&P - 2.7%, Nasdaq - 3.6% (worst since April)[146][147]. Tech and chip stocks lead losses[148]. Fortune: Warns Trump's move may backfire; gold and crypto jump as safe havens[144]. Carson Group strategist: “Came out of nowhere... extreme volatility”[73].	a 100% tariff = huge inflation + demand shock. Odds of recession soar. If it stuck, Fed would consider emergency easing. (But events moved quickly; by time Fed would react, Trump reversed course.) The VIX spike to multi-month high[149] reflects this fear. Fed staff probably start contingency plans if trade war reignites.	MOFA calls 100% threat “economic terrorism.” Behind scenes, China signals it would retaliate tit-for-tat (was reportedly readying 125% on U.S. goods)[52][54]. But Beijing also holds off making any rash move, waiting to see if Trump is serious or just leveraging.	l damage of U.S.-China rupture. Global markets swoon on Oct 10 (Europe's STOXX index down ~2%). European leaders implore both sides to keep talking. EU companies with China exposure (e.g. German automakers) plunge on threat of demand collapse.	guard – complacency shattered. Heavy selling by retail on Oct 10's drop (some stop-losses hit). Sentiment briefly turns fearful (“is TACO dead?”). Retail forums light up with concern that “maybe this time he means it.” Those who believed in TACO and held positions felt pain, though some held faith it's negotiation tactic.
10/13/2025	Trump backtrack	Reuters: “Equities	Fed: Huge relief –	China: Expresses	Europe: Stocks	Retail: Many feel

날짜 (Date)	정치 (Politics)	기관 (Institutions /Media)	Fed (연준)	중국 (China)	유럽 (Europe)	개인 투자자 (Retail)
 (Trump Revers es – Market s Rebou nd)	s: says U.S. “doesn’t want to hurt China”[15 1][152], adopts conciliator y tone on Truth Social. Treasury Sec. Bessent confirms Trump-Xi meeting at APEC is on[152][18 0]. Effectively shelves 100% tariff threat (not mentioned again).	rebound after Trump cools China rhetoric”[10 6][151]. Notes global index +1% regain[106]. U.S. Dow +1.3%, S&P +1.5%, Nasdaq +2.2%[153]. Analyst s: Zaccarelli (Northlight): “They’ve walked it back...hope for compromise returns.”[15 5][181]. Guardia n: Points out this fits pattern – Trump ultimately won’t implode market he sees as success metric[141].	potential crisis averted again. Powell likely thinks privately that political uncertain y remains biggest economic risk. Fed stays on hold in October meeting, citing recent “easing of trade tensions” but readiness to act if needed.	optimism: Commerce Ministry welcomes U.S. “goodwill.” Stocks in Shanghai rise modestly. Xi agrees to meet Trump at APEC in Seoul (late Oct). Chinese media cautious – notes U.S. unpredictabilit y but calls Trump’s softening “rational.”	and euro rebound as trade war fears ebb. EU officials relieved; hope APEC meeting yields lasting U.S.- China peace (so global trade can normaliz e). Some EU diplomats s wryly note “Told you so – Trump always blinks” in private conversa tions.	vindicated in TACO belief – those who held through drop recoup losses. However, nerves are wearing thin. Some small investors say they’re tired of volatility and trimming exposure. Others continue to ride the rollercoast er, reasoning that as long as Trump needs markets high (for re- election or ego), he’ll reverse any severe drop. Gold’s record high (~\$4100)[1

날짜 (Date)	정치 (Politics)	기관 (Institutions /Media)	Fed (연준)	중국 (China)	유럽 (Europe)	개인 투자자 (Retail)
						54][107] signals some retail (and institutiona l) money still seeking hedges.

Key Takeaways: From April’s tariff-induced crash to October’s tariff scare redux, **the U.S. stock market in 2025 has been on a wild policy-driven ride**. Politically, Trump’s aggressive trade and foreign policy moves caused severe market turmoil, but time and again he “**chickened out**” (**TACO**) when faced with a market meltdown or economic fallout[31][46]. Financial institutions and media have grown adept at reading this pattern – initially panicking at shocks, then cautiously betting on Trump to reverse course[73][151]. The Fed has been stuck in wait-and-see mode, balancing tariff-driven inflation risks against growth threats[26][27], all while trying not to react to every market flutter. China and other nations, for their part, have mostly stood firm against U.S. pressure (with the notable exception of U.S. allies who cut deals). **China, especially, refused to capitulate** – indeed by October media framed it as *Trump* having effectively capitulated by not enforcing his ultimatums[19][151]. Europe initially vowed retaliation but eventually compromised (halving tariffs via a deal) when economic reality hit[115][116].

Crucially, **accusations of market manipulation have swirled around Trump’s actions**. His well-timed “buy stocks” pronouncements[36][38] and sudden policy pivots benefited those in the know (intentionally or not). While some call it **savvy leadership in using the market as leverage**, others call it **reckless and possibly corrupt** (hence calls for investigations)[38]. Ordinary retail investors have been alternately scared and opportunistic – some burned by whipsaw moves, others profiting by trusting the TACO pattern. The pervasive view now is that **Trump treats the stock market as a scorecard** and won’t stomach a prolonged plunge[32]. This belief has itself become a stabilizing (if uneasy) force in the market.

As of October 20, 2025, with an APEC meeting on the horizon where Trump and Xi are expected to talk, investors remain on high alert. The term “**TACO**” – “**Trump Always Chickens Out**” – has proven true so far[31][46]. But many wonder: *what if one day he doesn’t?* For now, the 2025 experience shows a pattern of **market-threatening bluster followed by strategic retreats**, leaving in its wake heightened volatility, skittish confidence, and a stock market often seemingly at the mercy of tweets and headlines

rather than fundamentals. The rest of 2025 will tell whether a lasting trade peace (and market calm) can be achieved – or if the cycle of tariff turmoil will begin anew.

Sources: [2][31][54][21][15][162][38][41][166][88][102][73][151]

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